POLICY BRIEF

Aligning Skills with Opportunity: Rethinking Youth Employability Policy in Nigeria

Evidence from Glowing Minds Initiatives' Graduate Employability and Student Leadership Programmes (2022–2024)

Glowing Minds Initiatives (GMI) · M&E Unit · April 2026

SDG 8: Decent Work & Economic Growth | SDG 4: Quality Education

KEY MESSAGES

- Nigeria's youth unemployment crisis demands a structural not cosmetic, response to close the gap between academic credentials and workplace competencies.
- Lack of Soft skills and emotional intelligence are as significant a barrier to youth employment as degree attainment, yet receive near-zero policy attention.
- Campus entrepreneurship ecosystems remain underdeveloped despite the large youth population in tertiary institutions.
- Evidence from GMI's programmes shows that structured, short-term interventions produce measurable employability gains and can be upscaled nationally and even internationally
- Federal and state governments must co-invest with civil society and the private sector in evidence-based employability programmes linked to real labour market needs.

53%	2,000+	110+	34
Youth Unemployment Rate (NBS, 2023)	Young People Reached by GMI (2022–2024)	Programme Graduates (2022–2024)*	Tertiary Institutions Reached by GMI

**Graduates of flagship employability programmes (GEP, SLEP, YCEP), 2022–2024. Sources: NBS Labour Force Survey 2023; GMI Annual Reports 2022–2024.*

1. THE PROBLEM: NIGERIA'S YOUTH EMPLOYABILITY CRISIS

Nigeria is home to over 220 million people, with more than 60% of the population under the age of 25. According to the National Bureau of Statistics, youth unemployment and underemployment rates remain critically high, with estimates placing combined youth joblessness above 53% as of 2023. Behind this statistic lies a structural crisis at the intersection of education, labour, market readiness, and policy failure.

Nigerian universities and polytechnics graduate hundreds of thousands of young people annually, yet the majority exit the educational system without the skills employers require. This mismatch is not solely about academic qualifications; employers consistently report deficits in communication, critical thinking, teamwork, digital literacy, and emotional intelligence among graduate applicants. A 2023 employer survey by the Lagos Chamber of Commerce found that over 70% of recruiting firms identified soft skills gaps as their primary hiring challenge, ahead of technical knowledge. GMI's own GEP 2.0 curriculum addresses this gap directly, with dedicated modules on emotional intelligence, self-discovery, and personal branding competencies absent from most Nigerian tertiary programmes.

The core challenge: Nigeria produces graduates. It does not yet consistently produce employable young people.

Campus-based entrepreneurship represents another underexploited frontier. With over 1.8 million students enrolled in Nigerian tertiary institutions (NUC, 2023), the campus environment is a natural incubator for entrepreneurial thinking. Yet university curricula remain largely theoretical, career services are underfunded or absent, and the link between academic programmes and real economic opportunity is weak. Young people on campuses are not being prepared to create jobs or to get them.

2. EVIDENCE FROM THE FIELD: WHAT GMI'S PROGRAMMES REVEAL

Between 2022 and 2024, Glowing Minds Initiatives (GMI) implemented flagship youth employability programmes - the Graduate Employability Programme (GEP) and the Student Leadership and Entrepreneurship Programme (SLEP) reaching young people across Nigeria mostly through virtual delivery.

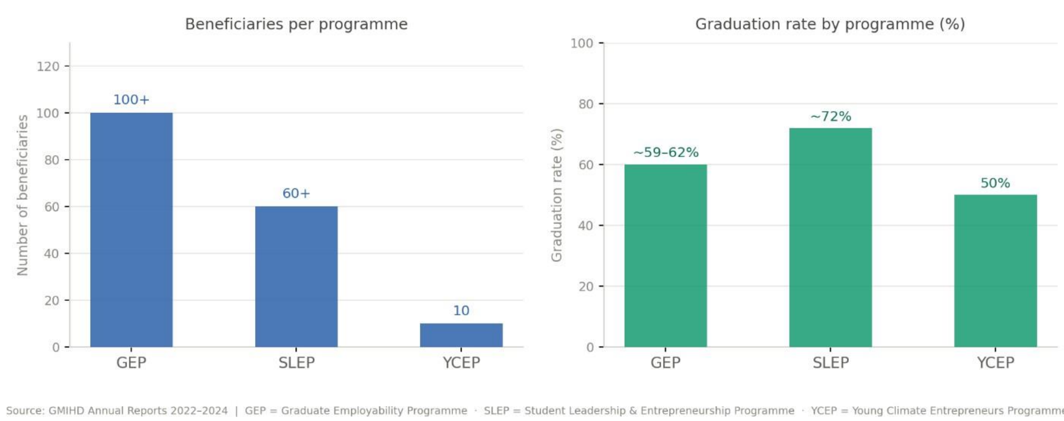
Across all three programmes GEP, SLEP, and YCEP GMI trained a combined total of over 170 beneficiaries and graduated more than 110 participants between 2022 and 2024, with YCEP additionally formalizing three climate-ready businesses from its first cohort. The evidence gathered carries significant policy implications.

Table 1: Summary of GMI Employability Programmes, 2022–2024

Programme	Target Group	Duration	Beneficiaries	Grad. Rate	Core Focus	Thematic Alignment
GEP	Recent graduates & young job seekers	6 wks / 18 hrs	100+	~59–62%	Soft skills, CV, LinkedIn, emotional intelligence, personal branding	Youth Employability
SLEP	Campus students (undergraduates)	6–8 wks / 24 hrs	60+	~72%	Business ideation, productization, marketing, business model canvas, funding access	Youth Employability / Gender Inclusion
YCEP	Young climate entrepreneurs	10 wks / 30 hrs	10	~50%	Self-discovery, personal branding, emotional intelligence, climate business development	Climate Change / Youth Employability

Source: GMI Annual Reports. Note: YCEP's 50% completion rate reflects the programme's 10-week duration and more intensive curriculum demands relative to shorter programmes.

Figure 1: Programme Performance at a Glance (2022–2024)



Source: GMI Annual Reports 2022–2024 | GEP = Graduate Employability Programme · SLEP = Student Leadership & Entrepreneurship Programme · YCEP = Young Climate Entrepreneurs Programme. Beneficiary counts are programme minimums. GEP graduation rate shown as midpoint (60%).

What the data tells us:

- Short-duration, structured interventions work. GMI's 6–10 week virtual programmes consistently produce measurable changes in participants' employability skills and entrepreneurial confidence. Beneficiary testimonials document gains in customer management, digital marketing, business financial literacy, and professional networking skills that formal education did not provide. Notably, three participants from YCEP's inaugural cohort went on to formalise climate-ready businesses a direct demonstration of the programme's entrepreneurial impact.
- Female participation reflects a gender inclusion opportunity. SLEP 2.0 data shows 19 female vs. 2 male participants a pattern suggesting either strong gendered marketing success or that male students face different engagement barriers. GMI recommends a dedicated male youth outreach component as part of any scaled campus entrepreneurship programme.
- Geographic reach is a programme strength and a policy argument. Reaching young people across Nigeria through virtual delivery demonstrates that scalable national employability infrastructure does not require physical presence it requires connectivity, design, and institutional backing.
- Completion rates reveal retention challenges. Graduation rates ranging from 50–72% indicate that dropout during programmes is a structural challenge, likely linked to internet access, competing priorities, and stipend absence. Policy solutions connectivity subsidies, completion incentives could close this gap.
- Employer linkage remains the missing link. While GMI's programmes develop employability skills, the pathway from training completion to actual employment or business formalisation requires structured employer and market linkage that civil society alone cannot provide without government and private sector partnership.

> *"The LinkedIn Optimization class gave me insight into what I can achieve. Before, I did less with my LinkedIn account and had very few connections. Now I try as much as possible to connect with people with common interests and engage more. It was a privilege to have my LinkedIn profile revamped."* ***Adaradohun Samson, GEP 2.0 Alumni***
>
> *"The CV review was a game-changer. The feedback I received was thorough and insightful, helping me craft a more impactful resume that truly highlighted my skills and achievements."*
> ***Adewetan Hafiz Adedotun, GEP 2.0 Alumni***

3. POLICY CONTEXT: WHAT EXISTS AND WHERE THE GAPS ARE

Nigeria has not been without policy intent on youth employment. Several frameworks and programmes have been introduced at the federal level, yet implementation gaps, poor coordination, and disconnect from civil society evidence continue to limit their impact.

Table 2: Key Federal Youth Employment Policies and Their Implementation Gaps

Policy / Programme	Intent	Implementation Gap
National Youth Policy 2019	Comprehensive youth development framework covering employability, health, civic participation	Weak domestication at state level; limited monitoring framework; no dedicated funding line for M&E
N-Power Programme	Short-term stipend-based employment for graduates in education, health, agriculture	Delays in stipend payment; graduates lack post-programme pathways; high dropout rates
YouWIN / CBN Youth Entrepreneurship Schemes	Business grants and financing for youth-led enterprises	Low awareness in underserved communities; complex application processes; limited CSO integration

NITDA Digital Literacy Programme	Digital skills training for Nigerian youth	Fragmented delivery; not linked to employment pathways; limited rural reach
National Employment Policy (Revised 2017)	Framework for addressing unemployment through public-private collaboration	Not updated since 2017; does not adequately address gig economy, remote work, or platform labour

Critical gap: **No existing federal policy framework systematically integrates civil society evidence into employability programme design. Organisations like GMI generate rich field data on what works yet this evidence rarely reaches the policy table. A formal mechanism for CSO-to-government evidence transfer is urgently needed**.

4. POLICY RECOMMENDATIONS

The following recommendations are addressed to three principal actors: the Federal Government of Nigeria (through relevant Ministries), State Governments, and Development Partners. They are grounded in GMI's programme evidence and the broader national context.

01

Integrate Soft Skills and Employability Competencies into the National Curriculum

The Federal Ministry of Education should mandate the integration of soft skills, financial literacy, and career readiness modules into the curricula of all Nigerian tertiary institutions. The National Universities Commission (NUC) and the National Board for Technical Education (NBTE) should develop standardised competency frameworks and require universities to establish functional career services units with minimum staffing and funding standards. Evidence from GMI's GEP demonstrates that even 18 hours of structured soft skills training produces measurable outcomes this model can and should be embedded at scale.

Key Actors: Federal Ministry of Education, NUC, NBTE

02

Establish a National Campus Entrepreneurship Infrastructure Fund

The Federal Government, working through the Ministry of Youth Development and the Small and Medium Enterprises Development Agency of Nigeria (SMEDAN), should create a dedicated funding window for campus-based entrepreneurship programmes. This fund should be accessible to accredited CSOs, universities, and private sector actors delivering structured entrepreneurship training. GMI's SLEP model which has already produced campus entrepreneurs across multiple Nigerian states and offers a proven, scalable template for exactly the kind of infrastructure this fund would support should serve as a design reference. Priority should be given to programmes reaching underserved campuses in non-urban states.

Key Actors: Federal Ministry of Youth Development, SMEDAN, CBN

03

Create a CSO-to-Government Evidence Pipeline for Employability Programming

The National Employment Council should establish a formal mechanism quarterly evidence-sharing forums, an open data portal, and a policy-research partnership programme through which civil society organisations delivering youth employability programmes can submit field data, beneficiary outcomes, and programme evaluations. This evidence should directly inform the design and revision of federal youth employment programmes. GMI and similar organisations are already generating this data; what is missing is the institutional channel to make it actionable. GMI's own M&E data collected across three years of programme delivery is ready to feed directly into such a pipeline.

Key Actors: National Employment Council, Ministry of Finance (Budget Office)

04

Expand Digital Infrastructure to Enable Remote Skills Training at Scale

GMI's virtual delivery model has demonstrated that geographic barriers to employability training can be overcome but only where connectivity exists. The Federal Ministry of Communications and Digital Economy should prioritise last-mile internet infrastructure in tertiary institutions and youth development centres across all 36 states. Subsidised data access for registered programme participants should be explored in partnership with telecommunications regulators and operators. Connectivity is not a luxury add-on it is a prerequisite for scalable youth employability.

Key Actors: Federal Ministry of Communications, NCC, MTN/Airtel/Glo Foundation Arms

05

Institutionalise Employer-CSO-Government Tripartite Partnerships for Job Placement

Skills training without employment pathways is incomplete. The Industrial Training Fund (ITF) should be restructured to facilitate formal tripartite partnerships between CSOs delivering employability training, employers in priority sectors, and government placement agencies. Graduates of accredited programmes including GMI's GEP and SLEP should be eligible for fast- track consideration in public sector internships, private sector absorption schemes, and enterprise support programmes. Evidence of skills attainment, not just certificates, should drive placement decisions.

Key Actors: Industrial Training Fund, NDE, Private Sector Coalition Against Poverty

5. CONCLUSION

Nigeria's youth employability crisis is not inevitable. It is the product of structural misalignments between education systems, labour market demands, and policy priorities misalignments that civil society organisations, development partners, and committed government actors are already working to correct, albeit at insufficient scale.

The evidence from Glowing Minds Initiatives programmes across three years and through virtual delivery nationwide demonstrates clearly: structured, evidence-based, short-duration interventions targeting soft skills, entrepreneurship, and digital readiness produce measurable changes in young people's employability trajectories. What has been demonstrated at the programme level must now be replicated at the policy level.

The five recommendations in this brief do not require new institutions. They require the political will to align existing structures the NUC, SMEDAN, ITF, the National Employment Council around a coherent, evidence-led vision for youth employability. This is not an aspirational statement. It is a policy choice.